

Functional equivalence

If two answer choices mean the exact same thing, then both answers are wrong.

Overview:

Periods and Semicolons

- 1.) If you have both a period and a semicolon in two answers doing the same thing, then the PERIOD is wrong.
- 2.) If there is no complex list, then the SEMICOLON is also wrong.

Colons and Dashes

- 1.) If you have both a colon and a dash in two answers doing the same thing, then the COLON is wrong.
- 2.) If there is no other dash that needs to be closed in the text, then the DASH is also wrong.

NOTE This rule works in any test where you can only pick 1 answer choice per question.

Ex.

$$\sqrt[3]{216} = \underline{\hspace{1cm}}$$

- A. 7
- B. $\frac{14}{2}$
- C. $\sqrt{49}$
- D. 6

Periods and Semicolons

All three can combine two independent clauses; therefore, two answers choices which contain them can be functionally equivalent (and, therefore, wrong).

Ex.

The children insisted on playing _____ until the sky turned completely dark.

- A. outside.
- B. outside;
- C. outside,
- D. outside

Ex.

The painting, which was created in the 18th _____ is now on display at the museum.

- A. century,
- B. century. It
- C. century; it
- D. century

NOTE: semicolons perform other functions (complex lists), so the mere presence of both answer choices only immediately eliminates the period. If and only if there is no complex list, then they are functionally equivalent.

Not functional equivalence

Two answer choices can only be functionally equivalent if they mean the exact same thing. Simply having the punctuation in the answer choices doesn't matter if they express different meanings.

Ex.

- A. of you as
- B. of. You as
- C. of you; as
- D. of you, as

Choice B and C are in different positions in the sentence

B and C are not functionally equivalent

Ex.

- A. bed he went
- B. bed. When he went
- C. bed; he went
- D. bed, he went

Choice B creates a dependent clause with the **subordinating conjunction** "when"
Choice C creates an independent clause

B and C are not functionally equivalent

Colons and dashes

Both can introduce explanatory information; therefore, they can be functionally equivalent in such cases.

Ex.

He ended _____ losing the race—which he didn't care about anyways.

- A. up,
- B. up:
- C. up—
- D. up